

Mindset, Certainty, and Cognitive Boundaries: Four Reflections on Personal Evolution

I had dinner with a few friends today and caught up on our lives. A few points resonated deeply with me:

First, a person's ultimate development depends fundamentally on their mental model—their values, their way of thinking, or how they define their own "identity." This is because values dictate all actions. If you want to become a certain type of person, you must look to them as a role model. Imitate their every move, study and mimic their thinking, and let that mindset naturally guide your actions. To become who you want to be, you must first build that identity. If you want to be diligent, first adopt the identity of a diligent person, study their thought patterns, and embrace the value of "diligence above all." Real change begins with a transformation of the "inner heart" (XinXing), which then directs a change in behavior.

There is a traditional saying that "a gentleman should be judged by his deeds, not his heart," but I believe this is flawed because the two are inherently consistent. The heart guides the deeds; the nature of one's heart manifests in their actions. Therefore, it is correct that actions reflect the heart. From this perspective, imitating someone is essentially imitating both their "heart" and their "deeds." While the heart guides deeds, the forced imitation of deeds can also reshape the heart. The two reinforce each other.

Second, reality is often uncertain, but people naturally gravitate toward certainty. Consequently, high energy always stems from certainty. Certainty is a "determined-to-win" momentum; it is a form of confidence and power. The key to motivating others lies in providing sufficient certainty. Whether encouraging someone or giving them energy, this is the most effective method. The subject of certainty doesn't necessarily have to be the one being encouraged; rather, it is the *encourager* who must be sufficiently and unshakably certain.

Third, a person's cognition is always bounded and limited. What we can do is continuously expand our cognitive boundaries. By interacting with people from different fields, we allow our understanding to extend as far as possible. Although cognitions vary from person to person, we can still communicate joyfully by seeking common ground while respecting differences.

Fourth, it is crucial to recognize the duality of human nature—both good and evil—as early as possible. Accept the world as it truly is and learn to navigate it accordingly.

In conclusion, much like the process of **Reinforcement Learning**, individual growth requires constant exploration beyond current boundaries. You might take hundreds of steps without a visible breakthrough, but once your "inner model" (your mindset and values) aligns with your "actions" (your deeds), you will reach a critical point of convergence and experience a sudden, powerful leap in personal evolution.